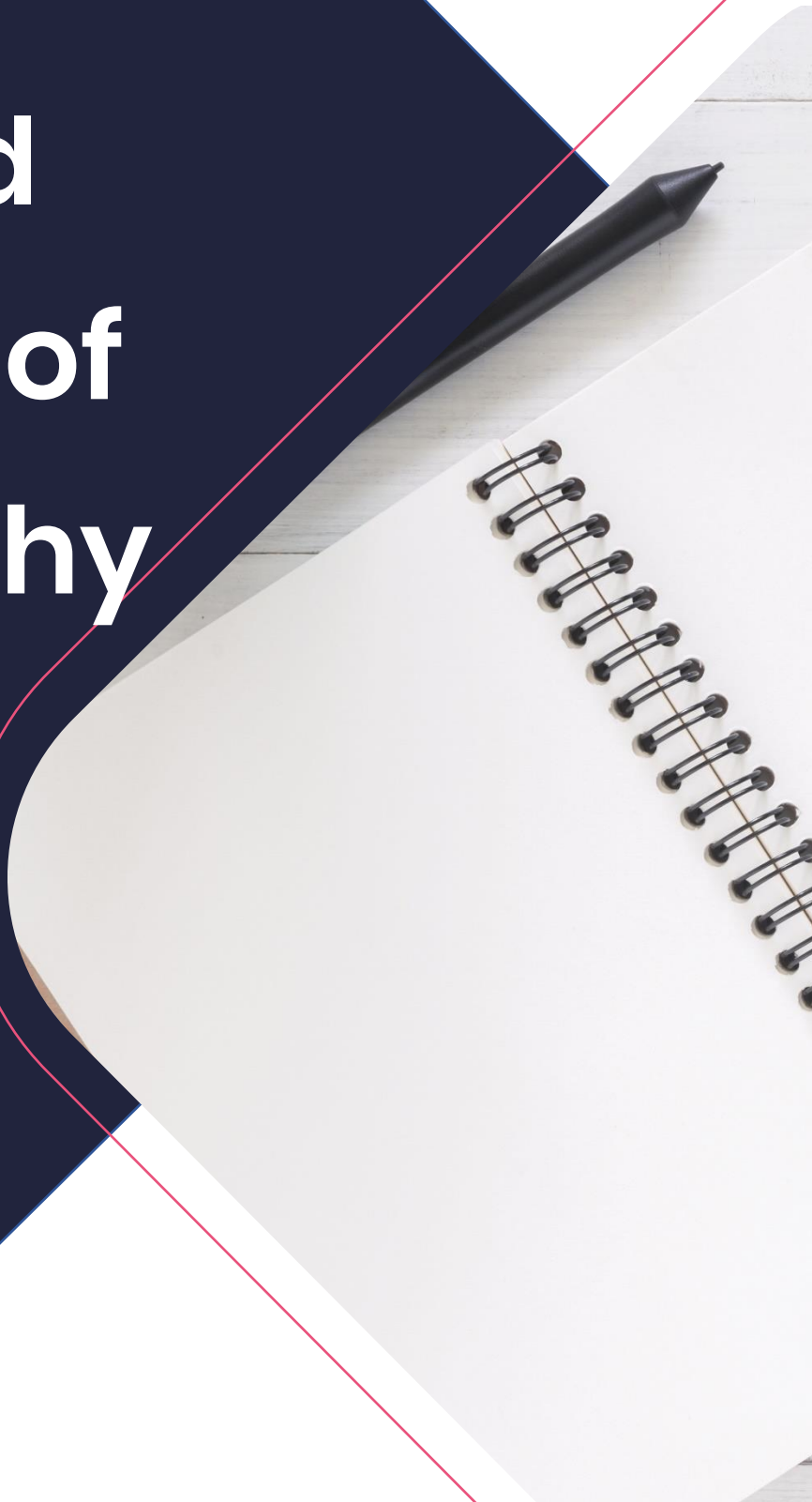
Graphic Design

Advanced Anatomy of Typography

Summary Notes



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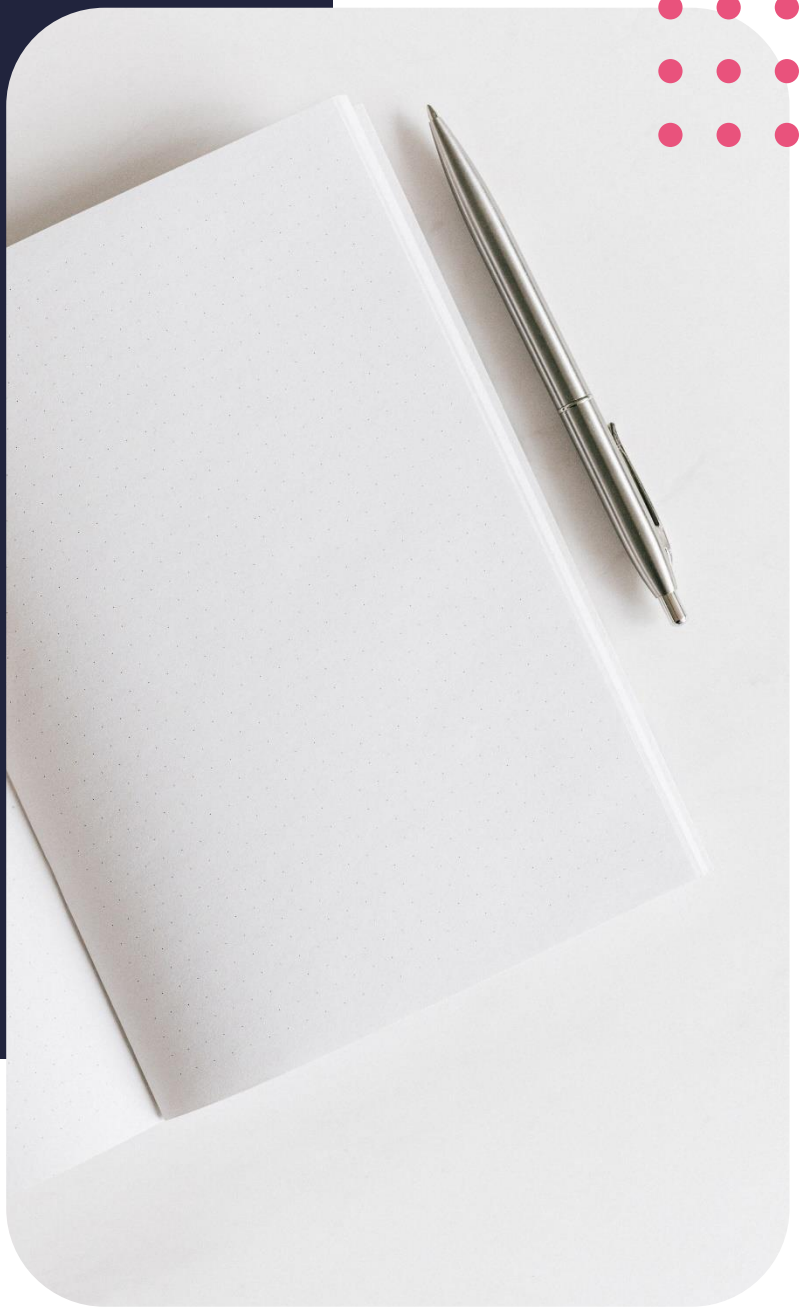


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: Anatomy of typography
- Lesson outcome 2: Typeface categories
- Lesson outcome 3: Working with typefaces
- Lesson outcome 4: Design with typography

Introduction

I'm sure, like myself, all of you have had a creative block – you know, you just don't have the capacity to come up with a clever idea or solution. But, how can you solve this issue?

Well, it is a known fact that by simply trying new things, you will become more creative. It is scientifically proven as well. By exploring new ideas and things, we release dopamine – which plays a major role in motivation and learning.

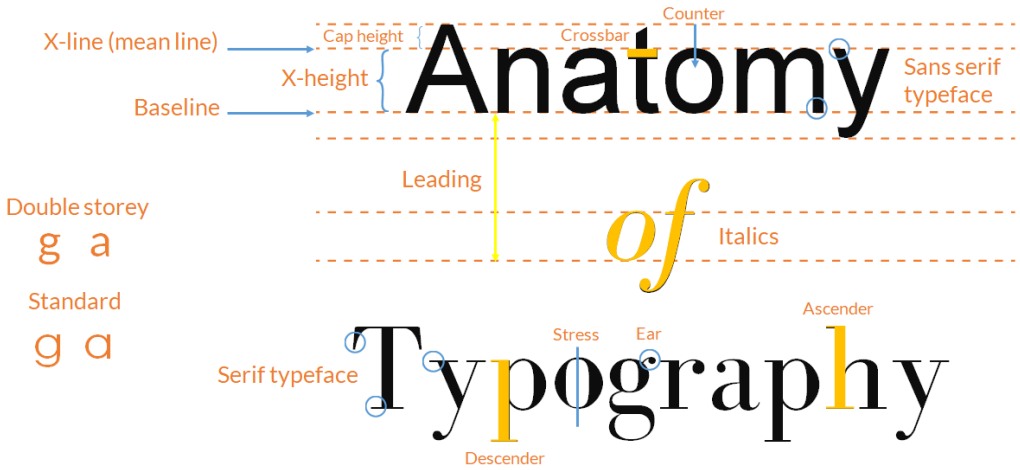
Scientific research conducted by Kaufman and Gregoire states that "the drive for exploration, in its many forms, may be the single most important personal factor predicting creative achievement."

Robert L. Peters is a Canadian graphic designer and author. He believes that "Design creates culture. Culture shapes values. Values determine the future." I want you to really think about this quote by Peters. It literally relates to how you, as a designer can make changes for the better. And those changes, through your design, can have a lasting impression.

Anatomy of typography

Typography refers to the technique and art of arranging type. All type you have ever perceived, someone, somewhere, had to consider the way it is perceived by others.
Have you realised that every single stroke and element on a letter has a name? I will familiarise you with the more popular parts of letters and then also how to speak proper graphic design lingo in a typographic sense.

Why is typography so important? Well, your typestyle needs to specifically address your message, since each typeface has a personality, just like colour.
It aids in evoking an emotional response as well. Typography is not only about communication, but aesthetics plays just as important role.
Did you know that type also makes out around 80% of most designs, so learn to view type through a designer's perspective from now on. Your work will look so much more professional! Breaking down parts of a font, you will soon realise that there is way more to type than meets the eye.



The anatomy of typography entails breaking each part of a font down. I will however not mention all parts but only the major, more commonly used parts of a font.

The height of all lowercase letters is known as the X-height. This is technically the distance between the Baseline, which is the line on which all letters rest as well as the X-line which indicates the top of all lowercase letters. The x-line is aka the mean line.

The cap height is the height of all capital letters

The typeface in which “anatomy” is typed in is known as Sans serif and the word Typography is typed in a Serif typeface. The difference between the two is that sans serif typefaces do not have extensions at the end of the letters and serifs have extensions which creates a more traditional feel.

The distance from one baseline to the next is known as leading.

As soon as a lowercase letter descends below the baseline, it is called a descender. And if a lowercase letter extends above the x-line, it is known as an ascender.

The word of is typed in italics which is a slanted version of a regular typeface.

The horizontal bar that we get in certain letters like the capital H, and lowercase t is known as a crossbar.

The counter is the enclosed or partially enclosed round or curved negative area of some letters like the d, o or s.

The stress refers to the angle of letters, where the letter is thinner in some parts. This is most obvious in the letter “o”. In this example, this specific typeface has a vertical stress as the angle is at 90°.

The stoke on top of a DOUBLE STOREY lowercase G is known as an ear and this is also the only letter to have an ear. You would have noticed that there are two ways to write a lowercase g an a. The one example is known as the double story G and A and the other is the simpler, standard way of writing a g and a.

This is obviously not all there is to know about typography, but these are some of the more used terms. To fully understand all these terms, we can go on about typography for days.

Typeface categories

Other than understanding the parts of a font, designers also need to know the typeface categories. Understanding this, will help determine the mood a typeface conveys and thus allow you to make knowledgeable choices when it comes to font choice.

The main font categories are

Serif

Sans serif

Display typefaces

Script

SERIF

SANS SERIF

DISPLAY

Script

Serif Typefaces

Serif typefaces convey a traditional sense and is normally used for body copy in printed documents due to its ease of readability when printed.

Body copy should be between 8 – 10pt & should be effortless to read. A lot of these typefaces have been around for 100's of years because they simply just work.

Examples include Garamond as well as Baskerville.

If you ever get confused, just think about the typeface Times New ROMAN as it is believed that serifs derived during the reign of the Roman empire when the letters that were chiselled into the sandstone buildings left a small extension at the end of these letters, which eventually became part of the letter.

Under serif typefaces, we have mainly 4 sub categories:

Old style — Old Style

Transitional — Transitional

Modern — Modern

Slab serifs — Slab Serif

I will break the characteristics of each apart and even though there might not be much of a difference between Old Style and Transitional to a novice, as a graphic designer, it is important to understand these differences for the sake of legibility.

Old Style

The characteristics of old style typefaces are that they have bracketed serifs.

These serifs start out thick at the stem of the letter and taper thinner to the end.

There is some contrast between the thick stems and thinner hairline serifs but not as drastic as with Transitional serifs, which we'll get to in a moment.

Also, most of the times the stress, specifically seen on the letter "o" is diagonal.

Old style typefaces provide the best choice for readability in printed documents.

Transitional

For the inexperienced, Old style and Transitional might look the same, since Transitional evolved from Old Style.

The key features in differentiating Old Style and Transitional is that Transitional has thick stems and very thin hairline serifs which provide even greater contrast than old style.

The stress of Transitional typefaces are also not at a diagonal angle but are normally vertical. The stress might even in some instances not even be present.

Modern

Modern typefaces normally don't have bracketed serif.

They have extreme contrast between the stems

with very thin hairline serifs.

Like Transitional typefaces, their stress is vertical.

This typeface works well for headlines or decorative purposes but not that well for body copy due to the extreme contrast.

Slab serif

Slab serif typefaces are quite unique in that their serifs are very much the same weight as their stems; hence, they are not bracketed.

These serifs don't taper, but instead, stay thick and even throughout.

Slab serifs create the illusion of a sans serif typeface due to their thick, bulky serifs.

Slab serifs were invented for display advertising and work very well for headlines too.

Slab Serif

Sans serif typefaces

Sans serifs are a contemporary typeface that was invented long after serif typefaces.

The word “sans” literally means “without” taken from French.

This means that sans serif typefaces do not have serifs.

Sans serifs can be used for a variety of applications ranging from headings to body copy in digital documents – if the typeface is not too busy but simple.

Sans serifs come in a variety of different typefaces from basic and simple like Lato, to decorative like Ethnocentric.

Lato Black

ARYA TRIPLE

Broadway

ETHNOCENTRIC

Display typefaces

Display typefaces, like the name implies are used for display or heading purposes

and thus, not always suitable for body copy.

Display typefaces can have either serifs or not.

These typefaces tend to be very detailed and have quite a lot of “personality” linked to them. A word of caution: Don’t simply use a display or decorative typeface simply because you like it. Determine whether it speaks with the same voice as the rest of your design does. Also, if it’s not legible, don’t even consider it. Just because you downloaded it from a font website, does not make it a professional choice.

By choosing the wrong display typeface, you might covey the wrong messages. So, it is crucial to understand the mood and feel a typeface conveys.

Chiller

Impact

ARYA TRIPLE

Ballet Harmony

Script typefaces

Script typefaces can also be used as display typefaces and are quite formal in appearance.

Script typefaces can be used in only a small amount of copy as it can exhaust your viewer quite quickly.

Ballet Harmony

Palace Script

Script is simply a term used to refer to a typeface that looks handwritten. Like cursive writing, script typeface letters are normally connected to each other, so when it comes to tracking, don't add or remove tracking to a connected script. It is best to leave your tracking on 0.

Another word of caution is that script don't work well in all caps.

Look at the typeface Braisetto on your right. The first option has too much kerning and the letters look like they don't belong together. This is a great example of why kerning should not be added to a script typeface. The 2nd option is typed in all caps and is just plain difficult to read, the last option at the bottom is just right. The letters are connected, and it is possible to read it.

Braisetto

BRAISETTO

Braisetto

Working with typefaces

At the end of the day, no matter how great or amazing you think a typeface might look, if it is not legible, don't use it. Legibility is the most important factor when considering typefaces. Also, don't combine too many typefaces. Normally one decorative or script typeface for headings and a very simple serif or sans serif typeface for body copy is more than enough.

I would like to leave you with some important points on working with type.

Firstly, avoid default typefaces. This refers to the default fonts already installed on your computer. There are so many options to choose from that you can download. Make use of the sources I have been providing throughout this course. Websites like dafont.com, 1001freefonts.com; urbanfonts.com and fontsquirrel.com offer a wide selection of thousands of typefaces. Also, please just consider the usage rights of these typefaces. It should list where the typeface is free for personal use, a demo or 100% free.

Next, steer clear of clichés – these include a lot of default fonts like Papyrus, Comic Sans, Curls MT but also fonts you can download like Scriptina. I want to show you a short video clip you can access on YouTube after this lesson. I will only play a short clip from this video for our lesson but do yourself a favour and watch the whole video.

Watch video here: https://youtu.be/jVhlJNJopOQ

This video explains exactly what I am trying to explain. The golden rule here is that they have simply been overused and are not unique. Some people might also place certain connotations to these typefaces, so, avoid them at all costs.

Next is to limit your typefaces. The rule is simple, your type design should not take away from your message and having too many typefaces is confusing and do just this.

Make use of two contrasting typefaces, one display typeface for headings and one simple serif or sans serif typeface for body copy. You can even use one typeface and simply change the font to create variety within your design.

Reverse type refers to a dark or coloured background and white type – this rule specifically applies to printed material but can also relate to digital material as well, especially if you have a very thin typeface and the colours from your background and type are quite similar.

Always ask yourself whether you can read what you designed and test this out on others as well. The number one issue your readers should NEVER be faced with is legibility and readability. A typeface might be legible but using too much script in a document can be tiresome and thus exhaust your viewer – this is referred to as the type's readability.

Lastly, a good idea is to make use of non-lining or old-style numerals. Non-lining numerals simply refers to numbers that extend above your x-line and below your baseline. It is not compulsory to use non-lining numerals, but they are more legible.

123456 **(NON-LINING NUMERALS)** 123456 **(LINING NUMERALS)**

Did you know that lowercase letters viewed from afar actually is easier to read, since the ascenders and descenders make the letters more distinct. This is the exact same with non-lining numerals since the extensions of the numbers are more legible in a lot of cases as they serve "ascenders" and "descenders" – like lower case letters have.

Design with typography

I hope you have made notes on everything that I said as we will be putting all of this into practice now. This challenge might seem quite difficult and has a lot of limitations, but these limitations force us to come up with other solutions – which is what graphic design is all about.

I would suggest you experiment with designing with type. It will really aid you a lot in future designs as the biggest part of your designs will most probably consist out of type.

The task entails to simply get a quote that you really love.

Then, simply, by making use of ONLY typography, type this quote in a creative and fun way. The rules are simple:

No colour should be used (you can only make use of black, changing the opacity or value is also not allowed).

No inverse colours either. This means that you can't make the background black and type white – sorry, not allowed.

Try limit your textboxes – this will aid you in understanding the character and specifically paragraph panel even better.

No shapes or lines can be used

No space bar in spacing out letters can be used; this is where you will rather make use of kerning

No diagonal rotation of letters

Reading all these rules, you might think that it is impossible, but I will do a demo to prove you wrong. I will be making use of InDesign but most of the functions that I will be using, will be available in Photoshop and Illustrator as well, since we will be making use of the Character and paragraph panel. There should also not be a great difference in working with these programs anyways, so I will leave the choice up to you.

If you really want to step up your game, I suggest you learn to design with type. There are few things as stimulating as accepting a challenge and successfully accomplishing it. Challenge and stimulate your creativity by looking at type differently from now on.

Conclusion

I hope that you will fall in love with typography just as I love to work with type. Our lesson today entailed the anatomy of typography and looking at the different parts of a font. We discussed the different typefaces from serif typefaces to script typefaces and I ended off with a challenging yet rewarding InDesign demo and designing only with typography.

References

Hagen, R. & Golombisky, K. 2017, *White space is not your enemy: a beginner's guide to communicating visually through graphic, web & multimedia design*, 3rd ed. CRC Press, Boca Raton, Florida.